

Almost everyone I met and ask about how they got to be an RSE will start by saying that they got into it in a bit of a weird way. Since just about everybody says that, I have come to the conclusion that there isn't an ordinary way to become an RSE. So I thought I'll share, with you, my story, the things I've done, the things I have learnt. If you're on the senior side of research software engineering you might nod your head in agreement and if you are on the junior side you might pick up on a few things to do or not to do.

I'll talk a bit about my life before being an RSE and then about our RSE team in Newcastle, my IRS (the old SSI) fellowship, CarpentriesOffline and running Carpentries workshops.

1. Where do I come from?
2. How did I get here?
 - ▶ Phase 1: South Africa
 - ▶ Phase 2: United Kingdom
 - ▶ Phase 3: Back to university
 - ▶ Phase 4: Post PhD



The reason I have the image of a river on the screen is because I think that illustrates how I went through life. Apart from knowing I want to do a PhD and having an incessant craving to know how things work and make things I didn't have any plans. I was in this river of life and went where it took me looking for opportunities to do things that I would enjoy. Sometimes you go through rapids and over rocks and you are head over heels but eventually you spot something that looks cool and you wade your way towards it.

I think I was about halfway through primary school when I asked my mom whether it was really necessary to go to high school before going to university. So it wasn't about whether I was going to uni but rather when. I didn't do well at school but I always loved learning and discovering how things worked. I didn't care for doing the best in class or scoring high marks but I loved reading encyclopaedias and figuring out how things work. All of this was pre-computers so programming wasn't an option yet.

So the part that is probably of most interest to you all would be phase 4. I'll just quickly

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vir CHO

It is now called

North West University



BA with Tswana, Sociology, Zulu,
Anthropology
Post graduate Higher Education Diploma

I always said I wanted to be a doctor but when it came to the end of school I knew I didn't not do well enough and we didn't have money for that anyway so I decided I'll become a music teacher and aim to one day do a doctorate to be a doctor. I went to Potchefstroom University in South Africa where my plans to do music lasted about three months because I kept falling asleep in the music history and didn't pass any of my tests, so after three months I switched to subjects that I could pick up that late in the academic year and ended up finishing with a BA in Tswana (an African language) and Sociology. I also did Zulu and Antropology. What I probably should have done was to study engineering or something but that wasn't something girls were steered towards in those days. I did in my fourth year buy my first computer, an Taiwanese clone of the Apple II+ and started teaching myself to program in BASIC

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And then of course I didn't go teaching. I joined military intelligence where I was a crypto analyst for two years. It was quite interesting and I did enjoy it for a while until I discovered the military intelligence was kind of a contradiction in terminology. But I did enrol at UNISA, the correspondence university, for a Diploma in Datametrics with Computer Science - which was a two year full-time course that took me ten years.

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And then I went teaching but I don't have any pictures of that.

But I taught everything I wasn't qualified for. Logic systems (or digital electronics and programming and maths and science. Fortunately the maths and science was at technical secondary level so it was probably less than what I did at school and I could cope with that. The logic system were covered by the diploma I was doing but I also started self studying logic systems at college level which was further education courses. I would just buy the book and go write the exam. Remember I wasn't bothered about doing well in exams - I was and still am absolutely crap at writing exams. If a pass was 50% and I got 51 then I studied to much.

I absodefnitelutely did not like teaching. So after two years I resigned)

- ▶ Programmer at a Municipal Pension Fund writing portfolio management software using Basic
- ▶ Programmer at Securities Trading and Technologies (STT) using UCSD Pascal
- ▶ Took two years out
 - ▶ Picked oysters in Kanyo down in the Cape
 - ▶ Worked as a fireman and paramedic
 - ▶ Was a Red Cross First Aid instructor
 - ▶ Wrote text books for Computer Practice and Typing Technique with my mom because there weren't any
- ▶ Savings ran out - back to STT

Then my savings ran out and I went back to STT

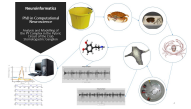
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This was fun and it wasn't fun.





Step number 1. Get transport because as you might know, in England there are trains and buses - but that's it - they are there. You can really use them if you need to be somewhere within a certain timespan. They might or might not show up. As we used to say in South Africa: You can't complain about the service because there is no service to complain about.



Enjoyed it very much. Was hard work because I was a single mum of two kids. ONLY had stipend to survive on. I got known for walking across campus with a yellow bucket with ice in it and those in the know knew there were crabs in it.

I would dissect the crabs remove the nervous system, place it on the rig and record the activity.

- ▶ Two years at the Bioinformatics Support Unit at Newcastle
- ▶ Senior Research Associate in Computer Science
- ▶ 2019 - the RSE team is established and I apply
- ▶ Each RSE has at least two projects

Lots of Carpentries related stuff start happening